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REAL PROBLEMS. SHARED WORK. MEANINGFUL LEARNING.

Making Real-World Learning Work

Scaling interdisciplinary, credit-bearing learning by making collaboration easier to organize and sustain.

Christopher Rogers

01

Work that matters

Imagine engineering, public health, design, and policy students investigating community water quality. With a partner, they test a prototype and refine a useful response. Faculty mentorship and academic credit connect this illustrative project to disciplinary learning.

02

What makes it possible

My exchange with Bass Connections director Meghan O'Neil highlighted the institutional work behind these experiences: connecting people, aligning incentives, and supporting teams from proposal to close.[1] Collaboration needs time and shared practices. Enthusiasm alone cannot organize it.

> Scaling real-world learning means organizing **the conditions that make it possible.**

03

Five decisions behind every team

A proposed starting point for institutional design

What must be resolved	What the university must establish
Orchestration	A program owner and shared project process.
Faculty incentives	Recognized workload aligned with teaching, research, and mentorship.
Academic credit	Learning outcomes, assessment, and degree credit.
Resources	Funding, staff, partner support, and compensation.
Coordination	Shared schedules, roles, project management, and interdisciplinary support.

Make the work easier to join and sustain.
Resolve recurring institutional decisions so each team can focus on its people, its learning, and its problem.

Make participation workable.

Start within one university. Build a repeatable way to support consequential work.

A PROPOSED DESIGN AND DELIVERY CYCLE

01
Frame
Listen to partners. Define a useful, achievable challenge.

02
Organize
Align people, credit, workload, roles, and resources.

03
Support
Prototype, test, coordinate, and coach the team.

04
Learn
Assess learning, gather feedback, and improve.

Return to the problem as evidence changes. Design thinking and product management guide the proposed approach.

04

Start within one university

1. **Choose a small pilot.** Bring a few disciplines together around a partner-defined challenge with an achievable outcome.
2. **Agree before recruiting.** Set credit, assessment, faculty workload, funding, and decision ownership.
3. **Give coordination a home.** Assign program support and a team project manager with clear responsibilities.
4. **Learn before expanding.** Track setup time, faculty effort, student learning, and partner value. Revise the model.

A longer-term ambition: extend collaboration across universities once the internal model works. Credit recognition, calendars, compensation, and governance would need additional agreements.

05

Support the whole experience

Bass Connections provides shared resources for team goals, charters, collaboration, and reflection.[2] Its project-management guidance calls for clear responsibilities and compensation, alongside continued faculty leadership and mentorship.[3]

What O'Neil's account adds

- A central team works with distributed theme leadership.
- Support extends from proposal development through the showcase.
- Leading a team usually does not count for faculty teaching credit.[1]

Design for the people doing the work

Faculty need time and support to lead collaborative teams. Students need clear expectations and feedback. Partners need a voice in defining useful work.

Make collaboration a supported part of learning.

The next design challenge is the institutional process that lets more teams do it well.

Research foundations: 1. M. O'Neil, personal communication with C. Rogers, October 2026. 2. Duke Bass Connections, Resources for Current Teams. 3. Duke Bass Connections, Project Management.

Scope: The five institutional decisions and pilot cycle are my synthesis and proposal, informed by these sources.